

deal. Mr. Flippen took me aside to explain what happened: Mr. Hersh tried to bid 80 and found no takers, so he'd come up to 85 to attract the seller. This 85 was short for \$285, what I'd just paid for one option on a contract for live hogs, good until October.

The young woman who'd sold me this option left the pit immediately and disappeared into the adjoining live-hog futures. "Probably laying off her risk," Mr. Flippen said. There's a great interplay between hog futures and hog options, just as I'd seen between stock-index futures and options back in New York.

"What does my \$285 represent?" I asked Mr. Epstein. He looked it up on a little tally sheet. "About 30,000 pounds," he said. My option gave me the right to a futures contract for that much hog until October. Considering the average size of a hog, which I figured to be 500 pounds, this gave me a potential controlling interest in 600 animals. Right then, I vowed to eat more pork chops and bacon, and to call my friends to beg them to do the same. Working together, maybe we could drive up the price.

Mr. Flippen pointed out a woman with a walkie-talkie who reported my trade to a central control booth. A few seconds later, the number 85 appeared on the hog-quote board and was flashed across similar quote boards all around the world. Seeing it above my head was as thrilling as seeing my byline in a magazine. "That's my 85!" I yelled to Mr. Flippen, and also to Mr. Hersh. Since hogs were slow, Mr. Hersh had returned to join our conversation.

I asked Mr. Hersh why hogs were so unpopular. He said a government report was coming out the following Monday, and smart money was holding off on any commitments. There was something wistful, even sad, about this quiet man in his orange-and-white checkered coat, but I couldn't stick around to find out what. Mr. Epstein was anxious to get back to work, and Mr. Flippen informed me the corn pit would close in 30 minutes at the Chicago Board of Trade. We left the floor of the Mercantile Exchange as quickly as possible and said our good-byes at the security check. I took a brisk walk over to the Board of Trade.

The interior of this art deco landmark was as impressive as the exterior. It had marble walls, decorated with intricate metal filigree, and lit with ships' lanterns. An ABC television crew was interviewing wheat-futures traders in the lobby for a documentary